

Collective Intelligence — Module 07: Communication

— Discussion Questions

20 unique questions on cross-team communication, boundary objects, alignment workshops, and boundary spanning.

1. Why is cross-team communication fundamentally harder than within-team communication? Frame the answer in terms of generative model differences.
2. How do boundary objects (Star & Griesemer) enable communication between specialists with different mental models? Give three examples from your experience.
3. Boeing's shared digital model for the 777 served as a boundary object connecting hundreds of engineering teams. What modern equivalents exist in your industry?
4. What characteristics make a good boundary spanner? Why is this role often undervalued in organizations?
5. How do alignment workshops differ from regular meetings? What specific design elements make them effective for cross-team model building?
6. When two teams have conflicting models of the same situation, how should the conflict be resolved? Through authority, evidence, negotiation, or some combination?
7. How does organizational jargon both help (within-team efficiency) and hurt (cross-team communication) model alignment?
8. Product managers are often described as boundary spanners. How does the Active Inference framework help explain what makes a good product manager?
9. How do dashboards function as boundary objects? What makes a dashboard effective for cross-team alignment versus merely decorative?
10. Assess the quality of cross-team communication in your organization. Which team-pairs communicate well? Which have the most model misalignment?

11. Identify a persistent cross-team miscommunication in your organization. Diagnose the root cause: Is it missing common ground, absent boundary objects, inadequate boundary spanners, or structural isolation?
12. Design an alignment workshop for two teams that must collaborate on a shared deliverable but have very different perspectives and vocabularies.
13. Create a boundary object (document, diagram, or prototype) that would help two specific teams in your organization communicate more effectively.
14. Your organization has multiple teams that rarely interact but whose work is interdependent. Design a communication system that creates appropriate cross-team connections without overwhelming everyone.
15. How should cross-team communication change during a crisis versus normal operations? Design protocols for both.
16. Compare three organizational structures (functional silos, cross-functional teams, matrix organization) in terms of their cross-team communication facilitation.
17. How do you build common ground between teams that have fundamentally different professional identities (e.g., engineers and lawyers, doctors and administrators)?
18. When organizations grow through acquisition, they face the challenge of aligning generative models across previously separate organizations. Design a 90-day cross-team alignment program.
19. How does the choice of communication technology (email, chat, video, in-person) affect the quality of cross-team model alignment?
20. Design a "communication effectiveness audit" for your organization. What would you measure, and how would you know if cross-team communication was improving?